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The Great Helmsman

> In the year 1906 some of the merchants of Tuticorin who were troubled and harassed very much by the British India Steam Navigation Company wanted to establish a Swadeshi steamer service between Tuticorin and Colombo and they asked me to join with them and work. I thought it was a laudable enterprise and would benefit the country very much, so I gave up my practice as a Second Grade Pleader and joined with them and started the Company.[1]

This was the plain and rather matter-of-fact sworn statement made by V.O. Chidambaram in court in the sedition case against him. What it masks is the rise of a small-town pleader to national stardom. The Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company Limited, Tuticorin was the cornerstone of this fame.

VOC's helmsmanship of the Swadeshi company for about two years pitchforked him to national prominence. The ambition and idealism of this venture fired popular imagination. And by mobilizing the common people, he emerged as the first popular leader produced by the Indian Nationalist Movement in south India. This was the defining moment of his career, a career cruelly shipwrecked by a brutal prison sentence. When he launched the Swadeshi company, VOC was a young man of thirty-four with a flourishing practice and a growing family. Two years later, he was arraigned for sedition and languished in prison for nearly five years, undergoing the harshest punishment.

In the glorious years of the Swadeshi movement, VOC combined politics with indigenous enterprise. How the idea of a Swadeshi shipping company germinated in his mind remains a mystery. Before he started on this venture, his interactions with nationalist leadership were limited, and it was only later that he came into direct contact with prominent leaders. It was not until the Surat session of the Congress that he even met Tilak or Aurobindo. It beggars belief that in a distant port town a small-time lawyer could conceive the idea of a shipping company to challenge the world's largest